tablished law. *Rivas-Villegas* v. *Cortesluna*, 595 U. S. 1, 5 (*per curiam*). To find that a right is clearly established, courts generally "need to identify a case where an officer acting under similar circumstances . . . was held to have violated" the Constitution. *Escondido* v. *Emmons*, 586 U. S. 38, 43 (*per curiam*) (internal quotation marks omitted). The relevant precedent must define the right with a "high degree of specificity," so that "every reasonable official would interpret it to establish the particular rule the plaintiff seeks to apply." *District of Columbia* v. *Wesby*, 583 U. S. 48, 63 (internal quotation marks omitted). *Amnesty America*—the precedent relied upon by the Second Circuit—did not clearly establish that Zorn's specific conduct violated the Fourth Amendment. *Amnesty America* involved a wide range of allegations of excessive force by police with no indication that the officers gave the protesters any warning that they would use such force. 361 F. 3d, at 123. Reasonable officials would not "interpret [*Amnesty America*] to establish" that using a routine wristlock to move a resistant protester after warning her, without more, violates the Constitution. *Wesby*, 583 U. S., at 63. The Second Circuit concluded otherwise by reading *Amnesty America* to establish the general principle "that the gratuitous use of pain compliance techniques—such as a rear-wristlock—on a protestor who is passively resisting arrest constitutes excessive force." 135 F. 4th 19, 35. But that principle, even assuming *Amnesty America* established it, lacks the "high degree of specificity" needed to make it "clear" to officers which actions violate the law. *Wesby*, 583 U. S., at 63 (internal quotation marks omitted). It does not "obviously resolve" whether using a rear wristlock to move a noncompliant protester after repeated warnings violates the Fourth Amendment, *id.*, at 64, as it fails to specify which circumstances make the use of force "gratuitous." Accordingly, Zorn was entitled to qualified immunity.

135 F. 4th 19, certiorari granted, judgment reversed.

PER CURIAM.

On the Governor's inauguration day in Vermont, protesters staged a sit-in at the state capitol. When the capitol closed for the day, police officers told them that they would be arrested for trespassing. They refused to leave. As officers removed the protesters one by one, Sergeant Jacob Zorn asked Shela Linton to stand up and warned her that he would eventually have to use force to remove her. She refused to stand. Zorn took Linton's arm, put it behind her back, placed pressure on her wrist, and lifted her to her feet.

Linton sued Zorn for using excessive force, claiming that the arrest left her with arm injuries and psychological disorders. The Second Circuit held that Zorn was not entitled to qualified immunity. We reverse.

I

On January 8, 2015, Vermont hosted the inauguration for Governor Peter Shumlin in the capitol.[1] About 200 protesters attended, and some of them staged a sit-in to demand universal healthcare. Shela Linton joined them. She planned to refuse to leave and anticipated being forcibly removed. "That's the point of the sit-in part of the protest," she later explained. Deposition of S. Linton in No. 5:18–cv–5 (D Vt., June 3, 2022), ECF Doc. 74–4, p. 127.

When the capitol closed to the public for the night, 29 protesters remained in the legislative chamber, sitting on the floor with their arms linked. At that point, police officers explained that they would arrest the protesters for trespass if they did not leave. The officers dealt with them one at a time; some stood up and were escorted out of the chamber without force, but others refused to stand and had to be lifted to their feet or dragged out.

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After removing more than a dozen protesters, the officers turned to Linton. Sergeant Jacob Zorn crouched down to speak with her, but she remained seated with her arms interlocked with those of her fellow protesters. As Linton passively resisted, Zorn unlinked her arm from another protester's, put it behind her back in a rear wristlock, and twisted her arm.[2] Linton exclaimed "'ow, ow, ow,'" while Zorn re-

[1] Because this case comes here on Zorn's motion for summary judgment, we view the facts in the light most favorable to the nonmoving party, Linton. *City and County of San Francisco* v. *Sheehan*, 575 U. S. 600, 603 (2015).

[2] A rear wristlock is a technique that officers use to gain control over a resistant person by gripping his wrist, placing it behind his back, and bending it backward. See Dept. of Justice, Use of Force by Police: Overview of National and Local Data 49 (Oct. 1999) (summarizing data

peatedly implored her to "'please stand up.'" App. to Pet. for Cert. 47–48. After Linton responded, "'I will not stand up,'" Zorn told her that he would ask "'one more time'" and then would use more pain compliance. *Id.*, at 48. Linton refused, so Zorn placed pressure on her wrist and lifted her up by her underarm. Linton yelled as she stood up. Once on her feet, Linton continued to jerk her arms and fell back to the floor. Zorn asked her to stand up again, and when she did not, three officers picked her up by her arms and legs and carried her outside. Linton alleged resulting physical and psychological injuries including post-traumatic stress disorder.

Linton sued Zorn under Rev. Stat. § 1979, 42 U. S. C. § 1983, claiming that Zorn violated her Fourth Amendment right against excessive use of force. The District Court granted summary judgment for Zorn after concluding that he was entitled to qualified immunity. The District Court reasoned that it was not clearly established at the time of the encounter that, in these circumstances, lifting Linton while putting pressure on her wrist violated the Fourth Amendment.

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The Second Circuit reversed. It held that its decision in *Amnesty America* v. *West Hartford*, 361 F. 3d 113 (2004), clearly established that the "gratuitous" use of a rear wrist-lock on a protester passively resisting arrest constitutes excessive force. 135 F. 4th 19, 35 (2025). It remanded for a jury trial against Zorn. Judge Cabranes dissented. "The case before us is not an exceptional case," Judge Cabranes reasoned, but "a routine arrest and removal." *Id.*, at 41.

II

Government officials enjoy qualified immunity from suit under § 1983 unless their conduct violates clearly established law. *Rivas-Villegas* v. *Cortesluna*, 595 U. S. 1, 5 (2021) (*per*

showing that "[w]hen the suspects used slight resistance, most incidents involved officer use of verbal commands, handcuffing, or wrist/arm locks").

curiam). "A right is clearly established when it is 'sufficiently clear that every reasonable official would have understood that what he is doing violates that right.'" *Ibid.* A right is not clearly established if existing precedent does not place the constitutional question "'beyond debate.'" *Ibid.*

To find that a right is clearly established, courts generally "need to identify a case where an officer acting under similar circumstances . . . was held to have violated" the Constitution. *Escondido* v. *Emmons*, 586 U. S. 38, 43 (2019) (*per curiam*) (internal quotation marks omitted). The relevant precedent must define the right with a "high degree of specificity," so that "every reasonable official would interpret it to establish the particular rule the plaintiff seeks to apply." *District of Columbia* v. *Wesby*, 583 U. S. 48, 63 (2018) (internal quotation marks omitted). Principles stated generally, such as that "an officer may not use unreasonable and excessive force," do not suffice. *Kisela* v. *Hughes*, 584 U. S. 100, 105 (2018) (*per curiam*). In short, officers receive qualified immunity unless they could have "read" the relevant precedent beforehand and "know[n]" that it proscribed their specific conduct. *City and County of San Francisco* v. *Sheehan*, 575 U. S. 600, 616 (2015).

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The Second Circuit contravened these principles. *Amnesty America* did not clearly establish that Zorn's specific conduct violated the Fourth Amendment.[3] Whether any particular use of force violates the Fourth Amendment depends on "the facts and circumstances of each particular case," *Graham* v. *Connor*, 490 U. S. 386, 396 (1989), including whether the officer gave "warnings" before using force, *Barnes* v. *Felix*, 605 U. S. 73, 80 (2025). In *Amnesty America*, the court considered a wide range of allegations of excessive force. The officers rammed a protester's head into a wall, dragged another protester across the ground, and

[3] We assume without deciding that "controlling Circuit precedent" can clearly establish law for qualified-immunity purposes. *Rivas-Villegas* v. *Cortesluna*, 595 U. S. 1, 5 (2021) (*per curiam*).

used rear wristlocks on two more protesters to lift them up before throwing one of them to the ground. 361 F. 3d, at 123. Nothing indicated that the officers gave the protesters any warning that they would use such force.

Amnesty America did not hold that any of those actions violated the Fourth Amendment, let alone all of them. Instead, it remanded for a jury trial because, while a "reasonable jury *could* . . . find that the officers gratuitously inflicted pain," it was also "entirely possible that a reasonable jury would find . . . that the police officers' use of force was objectively reasonable given the circumstances." *Id.*, at 124 (emphasis added). Relevant here, *Amnesty America* even relied on a decision approving the practice of warning protesters and then using wristlocks to move them. *Ibid.* (citing *Forrester* v. *San Diego*, 25 F. 3d 804, 807–808 (CA9 1994)).

Reasonable officials would not "interpret [*Amnesty America*] to establish" that using a routine wristlock to move a resistant protester after warning her, without more, violates the Constitution. *Wesby*, 583 U. S., at 63; see *Sheehan*, 575 U. S., at 615–616. Zorn repeatedly warned Linton that he would have to use more force if she did not stand up, and when she did not do so, he used a wristlock to bring Linton to her feet. See App. to Pet. for Cert. 47–49. *Amnesty America* never "held" that such conduct alone "violated" the Fourth Amendment. *Emmons*, 586 U. S., at 43 (internal quotation marks omitted). If anything, it implied the opposite. See *Amnesty America*, 361 F. 3d, at 124 (citing *Forrester*, 25 F. 3d, at 807–808). And its statement that officers who had engaged in a wide range of aggressive conduct may have used excessive force did not "put [Zorn] on notice that his specific conduct was unlawful." *Rivas-Villegas*, 595 U. S., at 6.

The Second Circuit concluded otherwise by reading *Amnesty America* to establish the general principle "that the gratuitous use of pain compliance techniques—such as a rear-

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wristlock—on a protestor who is passively resisting arrest constitutes excessive force." 135 F. 4th, at 35 (case below). But that principle, even assuming *Amnesty America* established it, lacks the "high degree of specificity" needed to make it "clear" to officers which actions violate the law. *Wesby*, 583 U. S., at 63 (internal quotation marks omitted). It does not "obviously resolve" whether using a rear wristlock to move a noncompliant protester after repeated warnings violates the Fourth Amendment, *id.*, at 64, as it fails to specify which circumstances make the use of force "gratuitous."

Because the Second Circuit failed to identify a case where an officer taking similar actions in similar circumstances "was held to have violated" the Constitution, *Emmons*, 586 U. S., at 43 (internal quotation marks omitted), Zorn was entitled to qualified immunity. We grant his petition for writ of certiorari and reverse the judgment of the Second Circuit.

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It is so ordered.

JUSTICE SOTOMAYOR, with whom JUSTICE KAGAN and JUSTICE JACKSON join, dissenting.

Sergeant Jacob Zorn used a "'pain compliance technique'" called a rear wristlock on Shela Linton, a nonviolent protestor who was peacefully demonstrating at a sit-in in the Vermont capitol. 135 F. 4th 19, 24–25 (CA2 2025). The Second Circuit held that Zorn was not entitled to qualified immunity on Linton's Fourth Amendment excessive force claim, at least at the summary judgment stage, because prior Circuit precedent had clearly established that using a rear wristlock against a nonviolent protestor would violate the protestor's constitutional rights. That decision was not erroneous, and certainly not so clearly erroneous as to warrant the "extraordinary remedy of a summary reversal." *Major League Baseball Players Assn.* v. *Garvey*, 532 U. S. 504, 512–513 (2001) (Stevens, J., dissenting). I respectfully dissent.